

One-Act Play
“Herod’s Private Eye”

(Kailani Bula, Ebenezer Lewatoro, Manamo’ui Lovodua, Joe-George Seniwaitui, Apimeleki Tawake)

Characters: Servant; Sam Spade; Shepherd; Wise Man; Angel

(All characters wear tunics, except Sam Spade)

[SCENE 1]

(Palace setting)

(Music)

SAM – (enters wearing a fedora and large overcoat, crosses strolling to audience)

The name is Spade....Sam Spade. Sam for Samantha Spade. I'm a private investigator. In fact, I'm the world's greatest private investigator. I'm sure you're asking yourself, "Who does this girl think she is calling herself the world's greatest private eye?" Well, I, Sam Spade, have been invited to the palace of King Herod, the king of the Jews. Needless to say the king wants the best private eye money can buy. That's me.

SERVANT – (enters) Are you Sam Spade?

SAM – (tips hat) At your service. Is the king expecting me?

SERVANT – The king wouldn't soil his hands with the likes of you.

SAM – (to audience) This is what happens when the world's greatest private eye handles a few divorce cases. Filthy business, divorces.

(to Servant) Well, the king sent for me.

SERVANT – You will be dealing exclusively with me. Here. (tosses a small pouch filled with coins)

SAM – (catches and shakes pouch) Must be a couple dozen coins in here.

SERVANT – There are thirty silver coins in there. That's the price of betrayal.

SAM – I would betray my mother for thirty pieces of silver. Who do you want me to betray?

SERVANT – The King of the Jews.

SAM – Hey, wait a minute. King Herod is paying me thirty pieces of silver to betray himself?

SERVANT – There's another King.....the Coming King.....the long-awaited King of Israel. When He comes, they'll call Him the King of the Jews.

SAM – I get the picture. But I'm not a hit man.

SERVANT – We're not asking you to KILL this guy. When he comes just tell us where He is. King Herod will send some soldiers to do the dirty deed.

SAM – Betraying the coming King of the Jews has to be worth more than **(jiggles pouch)** just thirty pieces of silver.

SERVANT – (snatches pouch) If you don't want the job, I'll find someone else.

SAM – Hey! I didn't say I wouldn't take the job. I just said it ought to be worth more, that's all. **(takes pouch back)**

SERVANT – Make it snappy. **(snapping fingers)** The longer He lives, the more likely people will become

attached to Him. **(exits)**

SAM – (mockingly imitates) “Make it snappy, please”. I’ll have this case wrapped up in no time **(exits)**

(Music and Lights out)

[SCENE 2]

(Bethlehem at Night)

(Lights on)

SAM – (to audience, strolling in) I made a quick check with the priests at the Temple in Jerusalem.

According to the prophet Micah, the Coming King of the Jews would come from Bethlehem. So, I headed down to Bethlehem, and you would not believe the stench. Turns out Bethlehem is where all the sheep are raised for sacrifices in the temple.

(sheep “baaaa” sound)

There is no way the Coming King of the Jews would live in this stink hole!

SHEPHERD – (enters) You calling my home town a stink hole, buddy?

SAM – Oh, I wasn't talking to you. I was talking to them. **(points to audience)**

SHEPHERD – (squints toward audience) There's nobody there. I think you ought to see a doctor!

SAM – Listen, my name is Spade, Sam Spade. I'm the world's greatest private investigator.

SHEPHERD – (2 second pause with a blank stare) Never heard of you.

SAM – (to audience) I told you this town stinks.

SHEPHERD – You're doing it again.

SAM – Listen, I'm looking for the Coming King of the Jews. I understand He's from this town.

SHEPHERD – Funny you should mention Him! The angels just told me where to find Him.

SAM – The angels?

SHEPHERD – Yes.

SAM – And you think "I" need a doctor?!

SHEPHERD – Believe me or don't believe me. He's in a stable on the other side of town.

SAM – The Coming King of the Jews is in a stable?

SHEPHERD – That's what the angels said.

SAM – Oh, great. A stable. More stench.

SHEPHERD – (continues to opposite end of stage) It makes no difference to me. I'm going to go worship
Him. (exits)

(Music)

SAM – (turns, follows strolling slowly, to audience) To say the least, I was a little skeptical. I didn't get to
be the world's greatest private eye by being gullible. So, I tried to find someone else in
Bethlehem who could confirm the airy-fairy story of that shepherd.

WISE MAN – (enters wearing headdress, hides face)

SAM – Hey, what can you tell me about the Coming King of the Jews?

WISE MAN – (tries to pass by) I don't know anything.

SAM – (resists) Hey. What's your hurry?

WISE MAN– I don't know anything. Please let me by. (freezes)

(Music)

SAM – (to audience) Rule of thumb. If somebody tells you he doesn't know anything, it means he knows something and doesn't want to tell you. Watch how I put him at ease and lower his guard.

(to Wise Man) You're not from around here, are you?

WISE MAN – No.

SAM – Where are you from?

WISE MAN – (tries to get by) Please, let me by. My people are waiting for me.

SAM – (resists) As soon as you tell me who your people are and where they're from.

WISE MAN – I don't think I can trust you.

SAM – Me? I'm harmless!

WISE MAN – You're from King Herod, aren't you? (freezes)

(Music)

SAM – (to audience) Now, how does this foreigner know I'm working for King Herod? I think it's time for a little deception in order to get him to lower his guard.

(to Wise Man) Who is King Herod? I'm a foreigner too. Should I be worried about this guy King Herod?

WISE MAN – King Herod is king of the Jews. When we told him that we were coming to worship the Messiah, he asked us to tell him where the Messiah is located, so he could come and worship Him too.

SAM – Messiah?! What's a Messiah?

WISE MAN – He's the Coming King of the Jews.

SAM – If you're a foreigner, how do you know so much about the Jews in Israel?

WISE MAN – I came from Babylonia with some wise men. We're disciples of the Jewish Prophet Daniel, who lived centuries ago in Babylonia. He told us when the Messiah will come and where.

SAM – Why would a bunch of non-Jews come all the way from Babylonia to visit the King of the Jews?

WISE MAN – According to the prophecies, the Jewish Messiah is the Savior of the whole world.

SAM – So, you found this Messiah guy?

WISE MAN – Yes.

SAM – So, where is He?

WISE MAN – I can't tell you. We think that King Herod will try to kill Him if he finds Him. We will not

tell anyone where He is.

SAM – Oh, you can trust me!

WISE MAN – Okay, I'll tell you. **(freezes)**

SAM – You will?

(Music)

SAM – **(to audience)** Now you know why I'm the best private eye in the world.

(to wise) So, where is the Messiah?

WISE MAN – **(points beyond Sam)** There He is!

SAM – **(turns)** Where?

WISE MAN – **(quickly exits)**

SAM – **(turns back)** Hey! **(looks around)** Where did he go?

(to audience) Alright, so, sometimes even the world's greatest private eye in the world can be fooled. Oh well...

ANGEL – **(enters)** Where do you think you're going?!

SAM – Who are you?

ANGEL – I'm an angel of the Lord.

SAM – An angel.

ANGEL – Of the Lord.

SAM – (to audience) I'm betting that there's a mental hospital in town and all the inmates escaped.

ANGEL – (squints to audience)

SAM – What are you looking at?

ANGEL – The audience. You brought the audience to Bethlehem with you.

SAM – You can see them?

ANGEL – Of course. I'm an angel.

SAM – Of the Lord, of course.

ANGEL – So, you're looking for the King of the Jews?

SAM – How did you know that?

ANGEL – I'm an angel. I thought we already covered that.

SAM – Never mind. Do you know where I can find Him?

ANGEL – You're too late.

SAM – Too late? Too late for what?

ANGEL – They've gone

SAM – Who's gone?

ANGEL – Mary and Joseph. I warned Joseph in a dream that that Herod was out to kill. They've taken the baby and are safe in Egypt.

SAM – Who are Mary and Joseph? And why are we talking about a baby?

ANGEL – The Messiah, the King of the Jews, was born here tonight.

SAM – Born? The Messiah is a baby?! I'm looking for a BABY?

ANGEL – You didn't know?

SAM – Nobody ever said anything about a baby! You mean Herod wanted me to kill a baby?

ANGEL – (exits)

SAM – (looks around) Where did he go?

(turns, strolls, talks to audience) The King of the Jews is a baby? Why didn't any of you tell me that the Messiah was a baby?

(holds money pouch in hand) You mean I took thirty pieces of silver to betray a baby?

SERVANT – (enters) You didn't find the Messiah, did you?

SAM – Why didn't you tell me that the King of the Jews was a baby?

SERVANT – (snatches pouch) I knew it. You didn't find him. (exits)

SAM – (follows) Hey, wait a minute! I need that money! What about my expenses?

(stops, turns, crosses as music plays) Now that I think of it, I'm kind of glad I didn't find the baby.

The New Coming King of the Jews couldn't possibly be any worse than the old one. **(points over shoulder, exits)**

End

©2013 Bob Snook (re-edited by Jeremy Waqa)

Do not sell any part of this script, even if you rewrite it.

Pay no royalties, even if you make money from performances.

You may reproduce and distribute this script freely,

but all copies must contain this copyright statement.